

Using GNU Emacs as an Internet Relay Chat

Internet Relay Chat (IRC) provides instant communication over the Web. It is generally used for one-to-one communication or group discussion forums, also known as channels. In this article in the GNU Emacs series, we will learn how to use GNU Emacs as an Internet Relay Chat (IRC) client.



Internet Relay Chat (IRC) is a messaging protocol that was created by Jarkko Oikarinen in 1988. An IRC server has a number of channels (or rooms, as they are called in other chat software) where both technical and non-technical discussions take place. Every user requires a nickname to chat. You will need to register your nickname with a password to identify yourself every time you log in to the IRC server. IRC can also be used for file sharing among users.

You can connect to a number of freely, available IRC servers. The most popular is Freenode (irc.freenode.net). The other IRC servers, to name a few, are IRCNet, OFTC, and EFNet. The Debian and Ubuntu projects have their own chat servers — irc.debian.org and irc.ubuntu.com. All IRC channel names begin with '#'. Some channels begin with '##'. Examples of channels are `##linux-india`, `#dgplug`, `#emacs`, `#ruby`, `#guile`, `#lisp`, and `#scheme`. You can also create your own channels, or host your own IRC server. Some examples of free and open source IRC server software are IRCd, UnrealIRCd and SynchroNet. Each IRC channel has a topic that can include useful links relevant to the channel. Sometimes, announcements or news updates are also mentioned in the topic.

Basic commands

A number of commands can be given to the IRC server. A few of them are discussed below:

1. `/list` is used to provide a list of all the available channels in a server. For example, `/list` in irc.freenode.net returned the following:

```
...
#lindod      1
#mwelding    3      Welcome to ##Welding, We're a little
bare at the moment, but will help if we can. Tutorials:
https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCJAFY2KXKb5sg79ld7T3hA
#drupal-ph   1      "Drupalista! Welcome to Philippine
Drupal Users Group. Have a good time chatting. If you have a
question, please don't ask to ask but fire up your question
in very specific and constructive way! Please join #drupal or
#drupal-support if no one is around"
#orx-project  4      Orx: Portable Game Engine
#tinkerforge 5
#osi         10     The Open Source Initiative
#xampp       1
#guitar      8
#bitcoin-ar  3      Comunidad Bitcoin Argentina
#LargeHadosaurCollider 19 Welcome to the LHC, est. 2001
| http://www.largehadosaurcollider.net | August Birthdays:
Digby 08/21, Josh 08/31 | At night it is pitch black, often
for months. | http://tinyurl.com/psgdag1
* End of /LIST
```

2. `/msg NickServ REGISTER password e-mail` is used to register your nickname to the IRC server. `/msg NickServ IDENTIFY password` is used to identify yourself to the server.
3. `/me message` displays the message for a user. For example:

```
/me says "Hello, World!"
```